Summer Mathematics Programs Consortium

Conference Reimbursement Policy: Specifics for 2026 in NYC

Local Transportation

New York City is a city with great public transit! Visit https://www.mta.info/ for directions.

The subways and buses are now enabled with tap-to-pay technology (it's called "tap and ride"), so you can use your Apple Pay, Google Wallet, or tappable credit card to pay for rides.[1] The system is not zoned, so you can get from anywhere to anywhere for $3 (with surcharges only in a few places, like the JFK AirTrain). In terms of reimbursements: since public transit is inexpensive, and since tap-to-pay doesn't usually provide a receipt, we are not planning to reimburse subway rides by default. If you plan to use the subway/bus and need to request reimbursement, please contact us to discuss.

If you need local transportation by car rather than by subway/bus (e.g. for mobility reasons or for safety reasons), feel free to use medallion taxis (you can still hail yellow cabs in the city with the traditional outstretch arm and flat palm!) or rideshare (Lyft/Uber have strong coverage) and submit receipts for reimbursement.

Using Your Per Diem

Breakfast, lunch, and snack breaks will be provided at the conference venue (Jane Street).

Dinner on Thursday night for workshop participants is on your own or in small groups; use your up-to-$50 per diem. The evening reception will include dessert.

Dinner on Friday night will be catered at the conference venue (Jane Street), and the after-dinner social gathering at the hotel (New York Marriott Downtown) will have central billing. If you need to make alternate arrangements (e.g. because you cannot arrive in time, or the catered meal does not meet your needs), go ahead and use your up-to-$50 per diem.

On Saturday night, we'll begin with a social at Clinton Hall, and food and drinks will be available; if that's what you'd like to have for dinner, then, perfect – you'll be helpful us to reach our food & beverage minimum. Feel free to use your up-to-$50 per diem to grab dessert or drinks with fellow conference participants after the big-group social. If you prefer a different dinner plan, feel free to use your up-to-$50 per diem to purchase dinner separately. (In terms of timing: the all-group social gathering will be relaxed, so it won't be a problem to arrive a little late or leave a little early in order to make your dinner plans work smoothly.)

To clarify: yes, you are permitted to use your per diem on alcoholic beverages if you are of legal drinking age in New York.

Finally, as a reminder: always keep receipts! And read on for more policy details.

---

[1] You no longer need tokens or MetroCards. There is now a thing called the OMNY card which is needed for special use cases, such as commuter benefits or senior citizen discounts; you do not have to have an OMNY card to ride the bus or the subway. You can use tap-to-pay with your card or phone.

Summer Mathematics Programs Consortium
2026 Conference Reimbursement Policy

Welcome to the how-to document for Consortium Conference participants about financial matters! This document describes the Mathematics Foundation of America's systems for reimbursements. (MFOA is the official name of the non-profit organization that houses the Summer Mathematics Programs Consortium.) Here's what is addressed in this document:

Specifics for 2026
Reimbursement Policy
Budget for each participant
Per Diem
Driving To/From the Conference
Travel to the Conference by Air, Train, or Bus
How to Submit Reimbursement Requests

If you have any questions, please email conference-organizers@summermathprograms.org and we'll be happy to help.

Reimbursement Policy

The Summer Mathematics Programs Consortium is grateful to acknowledge our generous supporters who are making our 2026 Conference possible. With their help, we will be covering participant expenses for those joining us in person so as to make the conference accessible to all members of our community.

MFOA will reimburse participants for travel expenses associated with travel to the conference that are not otherwise covered. If you have another source of funding—for example, grant funding that covers this trip—please use that funding source as primary and MFOA as secondary. MFOA will also cover the cost of hotels and meals during the event.

Expenses must be substantiated with receipts and submitted with a request for reimbursement within a reasonable amount of time after incurring the expense. The request for reimbursement can be made prior to the conference (i.e. after a flight purchase has been made, for example), and the final deadline for reimbursement requests is **November 30, 2026.** We cannot reimburse expenses incurred that are not adequately substantiated. (See below for details on how to substantiate mileage reimbursements; contact us with questions about other expenses without receipts.)

These policies are as flexible as possible to allow for each traveler to make the decisions that work best for them; in return, we ask each visitor to keep in mind that we're a small non-profit. (For instance: If you live in Albany, New York and the conference is in New York City, we will follow up with questions if you put in a request for $1,000 of travel expenses.)

Budget for each participant

Travel: $1000
In 2026, MFOA's reimbursement cap for travel *inside* North America is $1,000. If you will be traveling from/to other regions, talk to us. The cap is meant as a general guideline, but costs even for domestic travel can vary widely; talk to us if your travel requires additional funding.

Hotel: $641 (Conference Participants) or $961.50 (Workshop + Conference)
We have reserved rooms in a block at the Downtown Marriott; we will cover the cost of rooms (individual or shared) for up to 2 nights (Friday, Saturday) for conference participants, or for up to 3 nights (Thursday, Friday, Saturday) for those attending the pre-conference workshop as well as the conference. We will cover the base cost of rooms and applicable taxes and fees; you are responsible for any incidentals.

Most Workshop participants will travel Thursday morning and arrive in time for our 3pm start, but for those coming from far enough away that this isn't realistic (e.g. from the West Coast or Europe), we've reserved a handful of rooms for Wednesday night. Let us know if you need one!

If you are staying at the conference hotel and book your reservation via our room block, you **do** need a credit card to confirm the booking, but the card should **not** be charged at the time of reservation (as the base cost will be added to our umbrella bill). If your card is charged, please contact the hotel to remind them that you're part of our block and thus part of the central billing. You do **not** need to submit centrally-billed rooms as a reimbursement request.

If you book a non-standard itinerary for your stay (e.g. you extend your visit to NYC and stay in the conference hotel for extra nights, or make alternate housing arrangements), you may submit a receipt for reimbursement and we will reimburse up to the equivalent dollar amount.

Per Diem

We will provide breakfast, lunch, and snack breaks, catered on-site at the conference meeting space; and we will either include dinner as part of conference evening activities or offer our conference participants a *per diem* of $50 per day if dinner is not otherwise provided.

Workshop participants may submit reimbursement requests for Thursday, Friday, and/or Saturday meals (up to $150 total) that are not otherwise included in conference activities; all other participants may submit reimbursement requests for Friday and/or Saturday meals (up to $100 total). See the “Specifics for 2026” page for further clarifications.

Driving To/From the Conference

MFOA will reimburse mileage for travel to and from the conference at the standard IRS business rate (as available on the IRS Standard Mileage Rates Webpage), up to the reimbursement cap; this is intended to cover both the cost of gas and the wear and tear on the vehicle. You may request reimbursement by submitting a mileage log as an attachment to the expense reimbursement request. (An image or PDF of Google Maps showing the round trip mileage will suffice as a log.) On-site parking (e.g. at the hotel) is also eligible for reimbursement.

Travel to the Conference by Air, Train, or Bus

What itineraries will MFOA cover?

- MFOA will cover the cost of standard economy class tickets. (Airlines often offer a discounted "saver" or "basic" class of service, but this typically comes with very restrictive policies; to provide appropriate flexibility, MFOA will cover the cost of "standard" economy seats.)

- MFOA will cover the cost of the cheapest *reasonable* flight. What is a reasonable flight? It is a flight which is not a red-eye, reaches the destination before midnight, is non-stop or has reasonable layovers, and is on a major carrier (as opposed to an ultra-low-cost carrier like Spirit or Ryanair). This may not be strictly the least expensive option (and prices naturally fluctuate), and it's reasonable to elect (for example) to take a non-stop flight rather than a slightly cheaper but much less pleasant trip with layovers. Nonetheless, we encourage travelers to plan ahead and shop economically. If you have questions about whether your preferred itinerary is reasonable, check in with the conference organizers at conference-organizers@summermathprograms.org.

- MFOA will cover fees for checked luggage. (Be reasonable; don't check 6 bags.)

- Airfare change fees will qualify if the change in flights was due to business reasons and/or requested by MFOA; fees for flight changes due to personal reasons do not qualify for reimbursement.

- Ancillary costs including parking, public transit, taxi, or ride-sharing services can be covered.

- If your travel (from initial takeoff to final landing) takes over 6 hours, food of up to $30 will be covered. You may purchase this meal in your flight or at the airport (or some combination). If your travel itinerary will take substantially longer than 6 hours and you anticipate spending more than $30 on food during your trip, talk to us about it.

- The same standards apply to train and bus travel. (To illustrate the parallels: it's reasonable to elect to take an Acela rather than a train with local stops; we do not cover the upgrades to First-class tickets.)

As always: don't forget to save each receipt (including those from your lunch and your parking and so on): you will need the receipts to submit reimbursement requests.

What if I want to book more complicated travel?
We will reimburse up to the amount of a *reasonable* itinerary on the route and dates which you would typically travel to the conference. Here are some example scenarios to illustrate:

- **Upgrades.** If you elect to upgrade your seat, you should submit a reimbursement request at the level of the standard economy fare for the same itinerary.

- **Multi-city trips.** If you are away from home before and/or after the conference and therefore not traveling from and/or to your home base, MFOA will cover either the cost of the multi-city trip (your actual flights) or the cost for the typical round trip (from/to your home base), whichever is less.

- **Making stops on the way.** If you would like to, e.g. visit friends in Philadelphia on your way from Europe to the conference, MFOA will cover either the cost of the trip with extra stops (your actual flights) or the cost for the typical round trip (from/to your home base without additional stopovers), whichever is less.

- **Extended dates.** If you want to arrive earlier or depart later, and if it is more expensive than on the standard dates, you should submit a reimbursement request for the fare for the itinerary on the standard dates.

If your travel is nonstandard and you will be requesting MFOA to cover less than the full amount of your trip cost, please submit the receipt for your purchased itinerary (on your preferred route) and, if different, proof of the cost for a reasonable itinerary on the route and dates for which you would typically travel to the conference.

How to Submit Reimbursement Requests

You can submit your reimbursement request through the Consortium Reimbursement Form. You may do this as early as you wish, and you may make requests in multiple stages or all at once. Please submit all requests no later than November 30th, 2026.